25

Co-dependent BRICS from above, co-opted BRICS from the middle, and confrontational BRICS from below

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There is enormous confusion about how the BRICS relate to the world order, as roughly ten different ideological and practical political stances appeared, ranging from adoration to profound hostility. These ten categories were described in this book's Introduction, and they appear to be sufficiently cemented so that, although we can expect movement between them, the very nature of BRICS – especially its leaders' potential to talk left so they can walk right – will continue to bedevil the work of analysis. The standpoint of critical anti-capitalism has informed the prior pages, but with Washington's hostility to Moscow just as intense, there will continue to be a frisson of anti-imperialism whenever the BRICS make pronouncements about global injustices, or launch new institutions that allegedly offer 'alternatives' to the existing system of power.

To make matters worse, Russia's hosting of the BRICS heads of state summit in mid-2015 appeared to have three overarching objectives: continue building Vladimir Putin's diplomatic support base in the context of ongoing war on its Ukraine border; finalise plans for the 2016 launch of the BRICS New Development Bank; and initiate (for the purposes of co-optation and legitimation) a 'civic BRICS' structure tightly controlled by the five governments (i.e. conjoining BRICS from above with the status quo-oriented forces within BRICS from the middle). From these political-diplomatic, financial and social control processes, we can conclude this anti-capitalist critique of BRICS and consider where resistance might lead in coming years. The geopolitical tensions